NATIONAL ASSEMBLY 7TH PARLIAMENT

PARLIAMENTARY STANDING COMMITTEE ON ECONOMICS AND PUBLIC ADMINISTARTION

REPORT OF THE OVERSIGHT VISIT TO OSHANA, OSHIKOTO AND OTJOZONDJUPA REGIONS FOCUSING ON THE MANAGEMENT OF RAILWAY INFRASTRUCTURE

REPORT NO. 10 OF 2025

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Acronyms

TNHL.....TransNamib Holdings Limited

SOE.....State-Owned Enterprise

MWT.....Ministry of Works and Transport

CEO.....Chief Executive Officer

SOE.....State Owned Enterprises

GPT ..... General Property Trust

1. Introduction and background

Railway transport plays a vital role in the transportation sector of Namibia, contributing significantly to the country's economy. It offers an economical, efficient, environmentally friendly, and safe solution for long-distance transportation of heavy goods.

Furthermore, Namibia has great potential for mining and industrial activities, which makes railways ideal for transporting heavy goods for long distances because of their ability to accommodate heavy loads without damage to the permanent way or the facilities as compared to road transport.

Due to the population growth, railway transport will be of interest to the country in future for both freight and passengers. It is, therefore, paramount to ensure its development and sustainability. In light of this, TransNamib Holdings Limited (TNHL), a State-Owned Enterprise (SOE) which was established by the National Transport Services Holding Company Act, No. 28 of 1998) is the national rail services operator in Namibia which provides all railway transport services within and across the border of the country.

It specializes in the transportation of bulk, break bulk, containerized freight and passengers utilizing rail transport as well as offers warehousing, storage, and property rentals to complement its core business.

It is against this background and as part of its parliamentary oversight function that, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Economics and Public Administration decided to conduct physical oversight visits of railway stations, railway facilities, associated infrastructure and property (movable and immovable assets) in Oshana, Oshikoto and Otjozondjupa Regions from 07- 10 August 2023.

The Committee is mandated to operate with a vision to promote infrastructure development and economic planning. In May 2021, the Standing Committee held a Stakeholders Consultative workshop which was attended by senior officials of the MWT as well as TNHL. The workshop report which included the findings and recommendations was subsequently approved in the National Assembly and transmitted to the MWT for implementation.

2. COMMITTEE MEMBERSHIP

Four Members undertook the visit namely, Hon. Mathias Mbundu, Deputy Chairperson and Leader of the delegation, Hon.Hamunyera Hambyuka and Hon. Apius !Auchab.

Members were accompanied by Mr. Ivan Skrywer (Parliamentary Clerk: Committee Services), as well as representatives from the Ministry of Works and Transport namely Mr Robert Kalomho, Ms Ilona Shikuti, Mr Jonas Hamalwa, and Mr Mike Rumsey and representatives from TransNamib, Mr. Webster Gonzo, Acting CEO.

3. METHODOLOGY

The oversight visit was executed using a comprehensive methodology. This approach included initial briefing meetings with officials from key entities such as the Ministry of Works and Transport and TransNamib officials including the CEO.

Subsequently, the delegation conducted on-site visits to various railway infrastructure, railway stations and associated facilities.

4. OBJECTIVES OF THE VISIT

The primary objective of this visit was to apprise the Committee members of the prevailing status of TransNamib's railway services, infrastructure and facilities. The visit aimed to provide a holistic understanding of the strengths, accomplishments, challenges, deficiencies, inadequacies, and potential threats within the railway sector, particularly within the designated core regions.

5. PURPOSE OF THE REPORT

This report's paramount purpose is to apprise and relay the outcomes of the oversight visit to the National Assembly.

The report presents the findings and recommendations derived from the visit.

Furthermore, the report serves as a platform for deliberation, consideration, and subsequent adoption by the National Assembly. It facilitates informed decision-making and strategic actions to address the issues and opportunities identified during the visit.

6. RAILWAY INFRASTRUCTURES VISITED BY THE COMMITTEE

The Committee visited the following railway infrastructures in the southern, central, and western links.

(a) Site visit to the Oshakati train station and associated facilities

(b) Site Visit to Ondangwa train station and associated facilities

(c) Site Visit to Oshikango train station and associated facilities
(d) Site visit to Omuthiya train station and associated facilities
(e) Site Visit to Tsumeb train station and associated facilities
(f) Site visit to Grootfontein train station and associated facilities.
(g) Site visit to Otavi Railway train station and associated facilities
(h) Site visit to Otjiwarongo train station and associated facilities
(i) Site visit to Outjo Railway train station and associated facilities

7. MEETINGS AND OVERSIGHT VISITS

7.1. Courtesy call to the Governor of Oshana Region: Hon. Elia Irimali

The Committee conducted a courtesy visit to the esteemed Honourable Governor of the Oshana region, Honourable. Elia Irimali During this meeting, officials from TransNamib

delivered a comprehensive presentation shedding light on the operational scope of TransNamib. It was emphasized that TransNamib is an operational entity spanning across ten (10) regions of Namibia, with the notable exception of Zambezi, Kavango East/West, and Kunene.

In terms of staffing, TransNamib maintains an extensive workforce, boasting a robust complement of one thousand and two hundred (1,200) dedicated personnel. The company's expansive portfolio encompasses three (3) key subsidiaries: Swakopmund Station Hotel, GPT TransNamib, and Namibia Rail Construction, each contributing to the diversified facets of its operations. TransNamib's railway fleet comprises seventy-eight (78) locomotives and an array of one thousand five hundred (1,500) wagons.

These railway 'workhorses' collectively facilitate the annual transportation of approximately 1.5 million tonnes of cargo. However, the company aspires to amplify this capacity significantly, aiming to reach the impressive milestone of 4 million tonnes per annum. Currently, TransNamib keeps 23 to 26 locomotives operational on a daily basis. To ensure optimal profitability and operational efficiency, the ideal requirement is a daily fleet of 34 locomotives.

Unfortunately, the company currently operates with only 24 locomotives due to constraints stemming from a lack of essential equipment and spare parts. This visit allowed for a deeper understanding of TransNamib's operational landscape and underscored the company's dedication to bolstering its role in the region's transportation and logistics sectors. It further highlighted the essential role of adequate equipment and resources in achieving the company's ambitious cargo transportation targets, aligning with Namibia's broader economic development objectives.

The acting chief executive officer also said that it was an opportune time to speak to law makers about legacy debt of the company as they need assistance to make the SOE profitable. Transnamib moves on average around 1.4 million tonnes per annum (estimated equal to 47 000 trucks of 30 tons each per annum). He further said that investment in the railway infrastructure was not done at a scale where it' is needed to be.

Aging Locomotives: The locomotives in service are significantly beyond their expected lifespan, with most of them ranging from 50 to 60 years old. Their age has made them increasingly unreliable. Procuring spare parts is a persistent challenge, exacerbated by extended delivery times, which can be as long as 6 to 12 months. These delays impact the efficiency and timeliness of service delivery.

Tsumeb to Oshikango, Walvisbay to Windhoek are the key routes for cargo.

7.1.2 Rail corridors

Tsumeb to Walvis Bay monthly transportation of acid to Rossing Uranium Mine contribute about 70% of income to TransNamib.

TransNamib maintains a network of vital cargo routes crucial for the efficient transportation of essential goods and commodities, contributing significantly to the nation's infrastructure and trade.

7.1.3 Key routes

(a) Walvis Bay to Tsumeb, Ondangwa, and Grootfontein (Minerals, Fuel, Cement, and Ballast): This essential route serves as a pivotal artery for the transportation of a diverse range of cargoes, including Dundee Precious Metal's fuel, cement and ballast. It facilitates the movement of goods across a considerable stretch of Namibia.

(b) Walvis Bay to Windhoek (Fuel): This route is dedicated to the transportation of fuel, playing a critical role in ensuring a consistent supply of this essential resource to the nation's capital, Windhoek.

(c) Windhoek to Hosea Kutako International Airport (Fuel): The connection between Windhoek and Hosea Kutako International Airport is instrumental in providing a seamless and efficient channel for the transportation of fuel to the airport, essential for aviation operations.

7.1.4 Plan to break through

Plan to have break through financial performance and be profitable by 2028. The company applied to DBN for a loan of N$26 billion to purchase locomotives as the current fleet of locomotives are over 60 years old and keeps on breaking down and causes delays coupled with unavailability of spare parts.

A life span of a locomotives is estimated to be 25 years only 6 locomotives are new, but TransNamib needs to operate with 50 locomotives to be profitable. They still need 44 new locomotives although they plan to procure in phases on a yearly basis for the next two years.

7.1.5 Poor condition of infrastructure

TransNamib cannot guarantee on time delivery to a client when deliveries are requested which puts the company in a very precarious situation. However, from Walvis Bay to Windhoek, Walvis Bay to Oshakati, Windhoek to Oshakati, the comapny can deliver to customers on time.

7.1.6 Some of the causes for poor or ineffective service delivery,

(a) Infrastructure is in poor condition and the rail infrastructure is in disrepair, with numerous line breaks occurring almost daily. Resources to provide adequate maintenance infrastructure and equipment are lacking for both TransNamib and the Ministry of Works and Transport.

(b) Operational Shortfall: To ensure optimal performance, a minimum of 34 locomotives is required, but there are currently only 24 in operation due to equipment shortages, however these locomotives are old.

(c) Safety Concerns - Kransberg-Tsumeb Line: The Kransberg-Tsumeb railway line remains a significant safety concern, with the most recent derailment happened in July 2023. Ongoing maintenance is being carried out to ensure safety and new railway line is planned to be constructed soon.

(d) Infrastructure Compliance: Only 24% of the railway network complies to the SADC standard of 18.5 tonnes per axle load. This shortfall is a result of budgetary constraints and insufficient funding for infrastructure improvements. It is essential to note that the railway lines are government-owned under the custodianship of the Ministry of Works and Transport with TransNamib being responsible solely for maintenance.

8. Key Projects underway on railway infrastructure in the North

8.1. Site Visit to the Oshakati Railway Station

Picture 1. Oshakati Railway Station

Construction of the Oshakati railway station is in progress and the completion date which was reported to the Committee was the end of September 2023. The delay in completion was attributed by floods and a lack of funds. Furthermore, the construction of the railway was in its final stages as most of the infrastructure was already constructed and completed.

Other Railway projects in the north;

(a) Construction of the Oshakati railway station is in progress.

(b) Construction of the Ondangwa – Oshakati Railway Line (Phase 4: Construction of the permanent way).

(c) Central- Upgrading of the Trans-Zambezi Corridor Railway (Upgrading of the Kranzberg – Tsumeb Railway Line).

(d) Other Key Studies Underway are the Trans-Zambezi Corridor Railway Extension (Feasibility study for the new line between Grootfontein – Katima Mulilo) as well as Trans-Kalahari Corridor Railway Development (Upgrade of the Windhoek – Gobabis railway line).

8.2. Site Visit to Ondangwa Railway Station

Picture 2. Ondangwa Railway Station

Ondangwa railway station is fully operational it is one of the largest stations of TransNamib. The railway also has depots specifically assigned to clients i.e. Ohorongo where they store cement onsite and further distribution in the northern areas. There is also a fuel storage facility and a large storage for concrete sleepers for the ongoing construction of the Ondangwa- Oshakati Railway. The station also receives 2 trains on a daily basis caring cement and fuel and other goods.

8.3. Site Visit to Oshikango Railway Station

Oshikango railway station is a white elephant, since the completion of the station it has never been used. The station is in a very good condition as security guards are deployed to look after the facility. The railway station was opened in July 2012 to serve the border town of Oshikango and Helao Nafiti town.

8.4. Site visit to Omuthiya Railway station

Omuthiya railway station is located about 2 kilometers east of the town, nearby the station is agriculture silos as well as other industries nearby. The station is on the eastern side of town in the direction of the future development of town.

The station is currently not operational; a few locomotives are park at the station. All cargo trains are distanced for Ondangwa and pass through the station. The cupboards in the station building are infested with termites although the building is in a very good condition.

There are no passenger services offered on this line although the railway line is in a tip top condition. The passenger train seen in picture 3, is only park at the station. TransNamib confirmed that passenger services is more popular to the south as most people prefer to use minibuses and big buses to the north. TransNamib is currently busy with de-bushing from Oshivelo to Tsumeb as bushes and shrubs have overgrown along the railway line.

Picture 3. Omuthiya Railway Station

8.5. Site Visit to Tsumeb Railway Station

Picture 4. Tsumeb railway station, onsite GPT TransNamib concrete sleepers

The Tsumeb railway station is very busy on a daily basis as it serves a host of customers i.e. Henning Crusher, Dundee Copper, Ohorongo cement as well as Namib Mills. The station sends out 2 trains to Otjiwarongo and 1 train to Rossing Uranium carrying acid on a daily basis.

Tsumeb station consist of different departments such as maintenance, engineering, telecom and radio department as well as security department.

Two trains operate on a daily basis from Tsumeb to Otjiwarongo as well as a single train on a daily basis to Rossing Uranium ing with acid. Whereas 2 trains operate from Tsumeb to Ondangwa daily with cement and fuel.

8.5.1 GPT TranNamib Concrete Sleeper (Pty) Ltd

GPT TranNamib Concrete Sleeper (Pty) Ltd is a joint venture with TransNamib, the company also operates in India as a state owned company in railways as well as in South Africa.

The company manufactures concrete joint sleepers for TransNamib. GPT TransNamib was established in 2010 and started with operation s from 2011 TransNamib holds 50% share while a local outfit Doros Investment Consortium holds 13% and GPT the rest. The management of the company is as follows: three nominated by TransNamib, two from Doros and one from GPT. This is a very commendable initiative as it this is the first of its kind technology to be broad to southern Africa.

GPT Skills transfer: only two experts are from outside the country while the rest are local. The facility has the capacity to employ 102 people.

Since its inception in the last 7 years the company was only operational for 3 and a half years. The company was temporarily closed closed due to limited number of demand for its products and as a result employees were retrenchments.

Challenges: some of the challenges face by the company is that it lost its trained and experienced personnel due to plant closure. After the workers were retrench and recalled when the company reopened there seems to be a lot of defect products reported due to the lack of touch by the employees.

8.5.2 New Products:

the company is Planning to venture into new concrete products Expand operations to achieve broader product range as most of this product type are imported from South Africa. The company also eyes the Zambian market as they put up advertisement there.

Picture 5. GPT TranNamib Concrete Sleeper

8.6. Site visit to Grootfontein Railway station

The delegation was informed by the representatives of the TransNamib management that feasibility study was done for a dry port and plans are at an advance stage. There is enough land available for a truck port at Grootfontein which is owned by Transnamib.

The Ministry of Works and Transport confirmed the planned railway infrastructure development known as the Zambia Namibia TransZambezi. The agreement is yet to be signed between the Governments of Namibia and Zambia.

The acting station master informed the delegation that at the station their main business is derived from Engen Oil and a scrap metal company which are making use of their service.

Picture 6. Grootfontein idle land of TransNamib which can be utilized as a truck port.

8.7. Site visit to Otavi Railway Station

The station is still operational but the absence of fencing around the station and the railway line is a serious concern, as the locomotives are exposed to all sorts of dangers as well as potential theft form outside. School and the community members cross freely between the trains and on the rails as accidents may occur and people's lives could be lost. TransNamib was advised by the committee to erect a fence similar to the standard of other facilities which are operational. The facility needs renovation and new visible name plates or sign boards for the station.

Picture 7. Otavi Railway Station

8.8. Site visit to Otjiwarongo Railway Station. Courtesy call on the Governor.

The Chairperson of Otjozondjupa Regional Council stood in for the Governor. She informed the delegation that they were worried about the standard of the railway as a derailment occurred the previous month and the train was carrying copper. However, the side was secured quickly before any community member could rush to that side.

She urged TransNamib as a very important stakeholder in development of the country to be visionary and come up with innovative solutions. The chairperson further informed the committee about the local master plan for the development of Aerodrome and the air strip as the air strip is in urgent need for upgrade and revamp. This situation is so severe that even the head of state cannot land on the current air strip.

8.9 Otjiwarongo Train Station

The station master informed the committee that their main business at the station is the transportation of fuel, copper, acid, charcoal and cement. Previously 150 containers used to transport charcoal on the railway but this business has also shifted to road transportation. Biomass is a possible business prospect for the company and something they are looking at as part of the future business expansion. The station has a staff compliment of 91 employees within 10 departments.

Rail transport compete with road transport:

TransNamib Limited is in direct competition with private road transportation a situation which is not supposed to be road and rail should complement each other. There is a need for urgent intervention as TransNamib loses a lot of revenue to road transport. TransNamib requested for dedicated cargo on the rails i.e. that dangerous goods, fuel, acid and dangerous goods not to be transported on the road. They also call for an embargo to be placed on trucks from 06:00 pm to 06:00 am.

In terms of derailments it was reported that there was only last year. TransNamib is said to experience a high employee turnover. At the same meeting, the acting CEO also called for government support for the next difficult years as they embark on the process to revive TransNamib as a business.

8.10. Site visit to Outjo Railway Station

The committee was informed that the Outjo railway station was a hub for transporting of charcoal, animals and animal feed, however the station is not operational since before independence of Namibia. The reason being that customers simply change to road transportation. TransNamib invited businesses to make use of the facilities but to no avail as the facility is now dilapidated. As Plan B TransNamib approached a local training

institution to lease the facility to train the youth. They also had a transportation company leasing from them which used to transport materials to the Kunene Region.

The fencing around the station was stolen, the railway line is overgrown with bushes and scrubs. The was a proposal on the table from a business person to remove bushes and grass and to get tree for charcoal, which was approved by management.

Illegal occupation

Partial land on the property is occupied by a farmer illegally and he is provided with water from the municipality but TransNamib request that it be closed.

In terms of the by-laws of the municipality, it provides that if someone does not occupy the land for more than 10 years, it can be utilized by the occupants of the land. TransNamib said that they are paying for rates and taxes.

Picture 7 & 8. Dilapidated buildings at Outjo Station.

9. Conclusion

This visit has underscored the pivotal role that railway infrastructure plays within the broader context of national and regional development. It is imperative that these efforts continue to receive the necessary support and resources to ensure the successful realization of their objectives, ultimately propelling Namibia closer to the aspirations outlined in Vision 2030.

TransNamib Rail infrastructure is in a very good condition from Walvis Bay to Oshakati, Windhoek to Oshakati and Grootfontein, the company can deliver to customers on time. This is mainly due to new railway lines and maintenance to the old lines. However most of the railway infrastructure in the rest of the country especially the southern part is in a very poor and worrying condition leaving the company in a very precarious situation to an extent that it can't deliver on delivering on time.

Some of the causes for poor or ineffective service delivery is due to operational shortfall, to ensure optimal performance, a minimum of 34 new locomotives is required, but there are currently only 24 in operation, however these locomotives are old and out dated with little or no spare parts available.

According to TransNamib in terms of Infrastructure Compliance only 24% of the railway network complies to the SADC standard of 18.5 tonnes per axle load. This shortfall is a result of budgetary constraints and insufficient funding for infrastructure improvements. It is essential to note that the railway lines are government-owned under the custodianship of the Ministry of Works and Transport with TransNamib being responsible solely for maintenance. It is thus crucial to prioritize the comprehensive upgrading of the railway infrastructure and equipment specially to acquire new locomotives to attract more businesses to TransNamib.

Ministry of Works and Transport, with other stakeholders should fast track the planned in dry port at Grootfontein with abundance of readily available land and appropriate infrastructure (see picture 6.), without any delay to enable trucks from Zambia and other countries to stop at Grootfontein and off load for onward transportation on railways by TransNamib i.e. copper and other heavy and dangerous materials on the rail to Walvis Bay. This will reduce accidents causing fatalities and injuries to road users but also from damage to the national road infrastructure, while saving money and time for businesses.

Now that the railway infrastructure is almost completed to the north of the country it is expected from TransNamib to revive the optimal usage of the railway network to Ondangwa, Oshakati, Oshikango as well as Grootfontein for rail transportation of goods/cargo and passengers.

TransNamib is further advised to revive and refurbish all ailing infrastructure to its former glory days including fencing of all TranNamib properties which is not properly fenced off for protection against vandalism and theft.

In terms of the The Regional Infrastructure Development Master Plan which Namibia signed at the SADC Summit in August 2012. The Regional Infrastructure Development Master Plan guides development in key infrastructure such as road, rail and ports, and also acts as a framework for planning and cooperation with development partners and the private sector. Infrastructure was also a key component of the Regional Indicative Strategic Development Plan.

The master plan is expected to be implemented over three five-year intervals - short term (2012-2017), medium term (2017-2022) and long term (2022-2027). This is in line with the SADC Vision 2027, a 15-year implementation horizon for forecasting infrastructure requirements in the region.

It is also in line with the African Union's Programme for Infrastructure Development in Africa (PIDA) and will constitute a key input into the Inter-Regional Infrastructure Master

Plan and proposed tripartite Free Trade Area of SADC, the Common Market for Eastern and Southern Africa (COMESA) and the East African Community (EAC).

10. Recommendations

These recommendations aim to drive progress and enhance the role of railway infrastructure in the economic development of Namibia and to Southern African Development Community:

10.1 National Planning Commission, Ministry of Finance and Public Enterprises, Ministry of Works and Transport and Ministry of Industrialization and Trade should support efforts by TransNamib Limited to prioritize the comprehensive upgrading of the railway infrastructure and equipment, especially to acquire new locomotives to attract more businesses to TransNamib.

The Office and Ministries above, should be mindful of Vision 2030 that states "the goal for rail transport is to significantly modernize and upgrade the railway infrastructure, aiming to establish Namibia as a regional logistics hub by tackling bottlenecks in the rail system, thereby boosting the country's trade competitiveness and facilitating faster, more reliable transport for both people and goods within the Southern African Development Community (SADC) market; essentially making rail transport a key pillar in achieving economic growth and poverty reduction." Some of the key points for this goal are:

Infrastructure upgrade:

This includes modernizing existing rail lines, enhancing operational capacity, and addressing infrastructure bottlenecks to improve transport speed and reliability.

Economic development driver

By improving rail transport, Namibia aims to stimulate economic growth, create jobs, and facilitate trade with neighbouring countries.

10.2 Ministry of Works and Transport should amend the Road Traffic and Transport, Act 22 of 1999 as amended and the Vehicle Mass Act, Act 1 of 1924 to keep our roads safe from dangerous goods, fuel and acids including agricultural produce as well as food items in large quantities and reallocate the transport of dangerous goods and fuel back to the railways. These could be in phases of which implementation should reach 40% by 2028 and gradual increment of year on year, until international acceptable percentage and standards are achieved.

10.3 The Maintenance function is pivotal in railway services. The Ministry of Works and Transport, National Planning Commission, Ministry of Finance and Public Enterprises and TransNamib should budget for adequate resources to attend to

maintenance work of the railway infrastructure as soon as any deformity is detected or reported.

10.4 Ministry of Works and Transport, National Planning Commission, Ministry of Finance and Public Enterprises and TransNamib; in collaboration with NamPort should construct the planned dry port at Grootfontein with abundance of readily available land and appropriate infrastructure (see picture 6.), without any delay to enable trucks from Zambia and other countries to stop at Grootfontein and off load for onward transportation on railways by TransNamib i.e. copper and other heavy and dangerous materials on rail to Walvis Bay. This will not only keep our roads safe from accidents causing fatalities and injuries to road users but also from damage to the national road infrastructure, while saving money and time for businesses.

10.5 Ministry of Works and Transport and TransNamib should revive the optimal usage of the railway network to Ondangwa and Oshikango for rail transportation of goods/cargo and passengers.

10.6 Ministry of Works and Transport and TransNamib should adequately budget for the completion of the rail network and infrastructure to Oshakati.

10.7 TransNamib should fence off the precincts of Otavi Railway Station to keep the property and equipment safe from theft and possible damage by the public. This will also prevent possible accident involving people especially young children. (see picture 7)

10.8 TransNamib should revive the Outjo Railway Station into a storage facility or any other feasible business venture as part of a gateway to the Kunene region.

11. IMPLEMENTATION OF RECOMMENDATIONS OF COMMITTEES

In accordance with the Committee Rules of the National Assembly, when the Assembly accepts, with or without amendments, any recommendation of a Standing Committee on any subject, and the recommendation requires an Office, Ministry, Agency or Government Entity to perform or to refrain from performing an action, the Office, Ministry, Agency or Government Entity must comply with the recommendation of a Committee adopted by the Assembly, within a period of three (3) months or earlier.

SIGNATURE

..... Date...13/2/2025

Hon. Natangue Ithete (Chairperson)

Hon. Mathias Mbundu (Deputy Chairperson)	.....
Hon. Dr Tobie Aupindi	.....
Hon. Apius! Auchab	.....
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